

**A**n honored colonel in World War II, General William C. Westmoreland came to the Vietnam War on the personal recommendation of Secretary of Defense Robert McNamara. However, Westmoreland's decision to wage a war of attrition on the communist forces of North Vietnam led to him being recalled from Vietnam to serve as Army chief of staff and left him with an ambiguous reputation.

Westmoreland was born in South Carolina to Eugenia and James Westmoreland, who was a textile mill manager. The Westmoreland family had an illustrious military history that stretched back to the Revolutionary War, a legacy that he would uphold. An Eagle Scout in high school, Westmoreland showed self-discipline and military bearing in his studies. In 1932, after a year at the Citadel, the military college of South Carolina, he was appointed to the US Military Academy at West Point. He graduated in 1936 with the highest cadet rank, and received the Pershing Sword in recognition of his skills.